

Style guide for the BVA veterinary journals

The veterinary journals use British English spelling. Our reference English dictionary is Chambers; our reference veterinary dictionary is Baillière's Comprehensive Veterinary Dictionary.

Abbreviations

Abbreviations

- Write out in full the first time they appear, including in the title, headline, or introduction/abstract.
- If an abbreviation is used in a title, headline, or introduction/abstract, write it out in full again the first time it is used in the main text.
- Define abbreviations the first time they are used in boxes, figures, and table captions even if they have already been defined in the main text or in previous boxes, figures and table captions.
- Do not use full stops within or following an abbreviation.
- Once defined, abbreviations can be used in subheadings and to start sentences. When an abbreviation comes at the start of a subheading or sentence, the next word does not begin with a capital letter. For example:
 - PCR was used to...
 - FIV in immunocompromised cats
- Do not litter a story or paper with abbreviations; if an abbreviation is used only once or twice, consider whether it can be dispensed with.
- If a quote uses an abbreviation that has not been previously defined, spell the abbreviation out [in square brackets] afterwards.

County names in the UK are written in full, so 'Hertfordshire' not 'Herts', 'Oxfordshire' not 'Oxon'.

e.g. and i.e. should ideally be written out in full as 'for example' and 'that is' within the main body text, but can be used in abbreviated form (e.g., when used in brackets or when providing many examples). No full stops are needed, but the abbreviated form should be followed by a comma. For example: i.e., e.g.,

etc – try to avoid using etc in the main text, and never write out in full. Use the abbreviated form without a full stop in figures, tables, and boxes to save space.

Genus and species names – write out genus in full on first mention (as for general abbreviations); thereafter, the genus name can be abbreviated. No full stop is used after the abbreviated name. For example:

Escherichia coli □ *E coli*

Greek letters – use symbols for Greek letters such as α , β and γ rather than writing them out in full.

US states – spell out US states unless part of a zip code in an address. The exception is Washington, DC.

Acronyms and initialisms

Acronyms are words made up of the first (or first few) letters of a series of words and are pronounced as words. For example, BEVA, LAVA, NICE.

Initialisms are formed from the initial letters of a series of words and each letter is pronounced individually when the word is spoken. For example, BVA, RCVS.

Do they need an article?

To decide whether the definite article is needed, consider how the acronym/initialism is used in a phrase or sentence. For example, 'a spokesperson for BEVA' makes more sense than 'a spokesperson for the BEVA'.

Use the definite article when referring to the BVA, the RCVS and the APHA.

The following abbreviations and acronyms are well known and commonly used and do not need writing out in full

AIDS

ANOVA

APHA (Animal and Plant Health Agency)

BCG (bacille Calmette-Guerin)

BVA (British Veterinary Association)

CEO (Chief executive officer)

CNS (central nervous system)

CT (computed tomography)

Defra (Department of Environment, Food and Rural Affairs) - also note style with initial capital only

DNA, cDNA

ECG (electrocardiogram)

EDTA

ELISA (enzyme-linked immunosorbent assay)

EU (European Union)

FITC (fluorescein isothiocyanate)

GPS Global Positioning System

HEPES (buffer)

Ig (all the immunoglobulins when referring to them specifically, eg, IgG – but not Ig in a general sentence)

LD50

LGBT (lesbian, gay, bisexual, transexual)

MRI (magnetic resonance imaging)

NSAID (non-steroidal anti-inflammatory drug)

PAGE (polyacrylamide gel electrophoresis)

pO₂, pCO₂ (partial pressure of oxygen/carbon dioxide)

PCR (polymerase chain reaction)

PBS (phosphate-buffered saline)

PDSA (no longer People's Dispensary for Sick Animals)

QRS (complex)

RCVS (Royal College of Veterinary Surgeons)

RNA, mRNA, rRNA, tRNA

RT-PCR (reverse transcriptase-PCR; not to be confused with real-time PCR, where 'real-time' should be written out, so could also have 'real-time RT-PCR'. If doing a search and replace, remember that some people use 'reverse transcription-PCR')

SD (standard deviation)

SDS (sodium dodecyl sulphate)

SDS-PAGE

SE (standard error)

TB (but bovine TB, then bTB)

TCID₅₀

UK

USA

UV (ultraviolet)

WWF (formerly the World Wide Fund for Nature)

Affiliations/addresses

Give a postal address for each author of a paper or letter. This can include the author's practice, company, or private address. The order of details in the address should be (not all addresses will have all these details): Division/Laboratory, Department, Faculty/School, Institution/Practice, Street, Town, County/State, Postcode/Zipcode, Country (if required – see below).

For states/provinces in the USA, Canada, and Australia, use the abbreviated code for the state name in the zip code: e.g., AK (Alaska), ON (Ontario), NSW (New South Wales).

Addresses in Europe should not have a letter and hyphen before the postcode, so 43659 not D-43659.

For Letters specifically

If the correspondent holds a particular position (e.g., chair, president, etc), include that after their name – **John Smith**, chair, Any Company, 21 Any Street, Any Town/City AN1 0YT

Country is not required for UK addresses.

One email address per letter is required, unless the author requests more, or there are multiple authors of high repute.

Where there is a long list of authors, provide the full address for the corresponding author; for the remainder, provide just their name and company/practice.

Authors of letters may remain anonymous if requested and agreed by *Vet Record*. These are styled Anon (name and address supplied).

For Research papers specifically

Superscript affiliation numbers are included in the list of authors at the top of a paper, with numbered affiliations given below.

An email address should be given for the corresponding author only.

Addresses in the UK should have 'UK' at the end but should not include England, Wales, Northern Ireland, or Scotland.

Animal adjectives

Use 'bovine', 'canine', 'caprine', 'equine', 'feline', 'ovine' and 'porcine' as adjectives only. Refer to 'cattle', 'dogs', 'goats', 'horses', 'cats', 'sheep' and 'pigs' instead.

human(s)/people – use 'people' rather than 'humans' throughout the journal. 'Human beings' should be used in research papers. 'Human' can be used as an adjective, e.g., 'human medicine'.

Capital and lower case letters

Minimise the use of upper case letters, particularly on job titles, etc.

- If a title is used but not as part of a person's name, use lower case. For example, Donald Trump, president of the USA (President Trump); John Smith, professor of veterinary immunology (Professor Smith).
- Government minister titles are lower case. For example, Boris Johnson, prime minister; Theresa Villiers, secretary of state.
- 'government' takes lower case as do 'opposition', 'member of parliament' and 'parliament'.
- Royal family – use a capital letter for the individual's title, but not for the article preceding the title. For example, the Princess Royal (not The Princess Royal), the Queen (not The Queen).
- Titles such as 'fellow', 'resident', 'intern' and 'specialist' take lower case (with 'specialist' the area of specialism should also be given; for example, 'RCVS specialist in internal medicine', 'European specialist in orthopaedics').

Brand names take an initial capital, generic names do not. For example: Nurofen (brand), ibuprofen (generic).

Breeds – breeds named after a person or place take a capital letter on the proper noun(s). For example, Labrador, West Highland white terrier, Cavalier King Charles spaniel. Note that Texel (sheep) is a place, but beltex is not (it is a combination of 'Belgian' and 'Texel' to reflect the breed's origins). Also, border terrier is lower case as it is not named after the Borders, but Border collie is.

Capital letters following numbers or lower case letters – for sentences that start with a number or a lower case letter, the first letter of the next word should be capitalised. For example, 3-Hydroxymethane, cis-Hydroxytamoxifen.

Computing terms should be lower case: email, internet, web page, wifi, worldwide web, and so on.

Disease names take lower case unless named after a place or person.

First words – the first word of an article is capitalised unless it is italicised (e.g., a genus name) or it follows a cross-/subhead or if it appears in a box.

Legislation – use upper case when giving the full name of a piece of legislation (a bill or an act), but then lower case when referring in general to 'the bill' or 'the act'; also 'white paper' and 'green paper'.

Open access – open access is lower case on all occasions. If used in section headings it should be 'Open access'. In the open access statements at the end of an article it should be: '**Open access** This is an open access article distributed in accordance with the...'

Organisations, committees, and departments – within organisations, committees and departments take lower case initial letters; the organisations themselves (when given their proper name) take capitals. For example, 'the education committee of the Veterinary Schools Council' or 'the veterinary pathology department at the University of Liverpool'. When mentioned in generality change to lower case when only part of the name is used. For example, 'the college'.

P values – use an upper case P.

Wars – all specific wars have capitals. For example, World War I.

Computer language

Program not programme when referring to computers.

Websites – use <https://> or [www.](http://) before a URL to indicate to readers that a website is being referred to. Do not use both (e.g., <https://www>).

If a sentence in the middle of a paragraph ends with a URL, then a full stop should be added. If the URL falls at the end of a paragraph, no full stop is required.

Countries and regions

British Isles includes Great Britain, the whole of the island of Ireland and all surrounding islands (Isle of Man, Shetland Islands, Hebrides, etc).

Great Britain refers to England, Scotland, and Wales only.

UK (United Kingdom) refers to Great Britain and Northern Ireland.

USA does not need to be defined. 'US' is used as the adjective 'USA' as the noun. For example, 'Exports from the USA' vs 'US exports'.

Currencies and money

Dollars – specify the country. For example, US \$, AUS \$. Leave a space between country abbreviation and the \$ sign, but no space between the \$ sign and the amount (US \$40).

yen, roubles, forints and rupees – write out in full.

Spell out 'million' and 'billion'. For example, '£1 million' not '£1m'.

Dates

Dates in the veterinary journals take the form 'day month year'. For example, '21 June 2019'. The day of the week is not usually included.

Diseases and disease agents

Coenurus cerebralis and **Cysticercus tenuicollis** are not separate species. Both are larval forms of tapeworms belonging to the genus *Taenia* and should be referred to as such. For example, 'the larval stage of the tapeworm *Taenia multiceps*' for the former, or 'the larval stage of the tapeworm *Taenia hydatigena*' for the latter (although these are not the only species for each). The diseases caused by these parasites are coenurosis and cysticercosis, respectively. If an author insists on using either name, it should not be italicised.

Genus – if referring in general to a genus, the genus name should be followed by the word ‘species’. For example, *Brachyspira* species; however, *Brachyspira*-positive would be acceptable.

Leptospira – the genus *Leptospira* currently comprises 20+ different species, with the species further split into more than 200 serovars. The genus and species names are italicised, but the serovar name is not. Serovar names take an initial capital. For example, *Leptospira interrogans* serovar Icterohaemorrhagiae or *Leptospira borgpetersenii* serovar Hardjo. Our style is usually to omit everything except the genus and serovar names. For example, *Leptospira* Icterohaemorrhagiae/*L* Icterohaemorrhagiae. More information can be found on www.bacterio.net

Parasitic diseases – follow the Standardised Nomenclature of Parasitic Diseases 2 (SNOPAD). Parasitic diseases take ‘osis’ as a suffix (‘oses’ in the plural) regardless of whether they affect people or animals. Guidance on forming parasitic disease names can be found in the paper ‘Standardized Nomenclature of Animal Parasitic Diseases (SNOAPAD)’ by Kassai et al, a copy of which is available on the Team Drive.

Salmonella – the genus *Salmonella* comprises two species, *enterica* and *bongori*. *S enterica* tends to be more relevant for the veterinary journals and is divided into six subspecies and then into more than 1000 serotypes. The genus, species and subspecies names are italicised, but the serovar name is not. Serovar names take an initial capital. For example, *Salmonella enterica* subspecies *enterica* serovar Typhimurium. Our style is usually to omit everything except the genus and serovar names. For example, *Salmonella* Typhimurium/*S* Typhimurium.

S Enteritidis can be further divided into phage types (designated PT) and *S* Typhimurium into definitive phage types (designated DT). DT and PT are written closed up to the number, (eg, DT104).

symptom – do not use when referring to animals. Change to ‘clinical signs’ or just ‘signs’. Symptom can be used if reference is being made to a condition in human beings, only in the context of the human disease.

Drugs and drug doses

Chemical formulae should be defined on first use. For example, ‘sodium chloride (NaCl)’.

Dosage refers to the frequency at which doses are given. For example, ‘4 mg/kg every 4 hours’.

Dose refers to the amount of a drug administered at any given time. For example, ‘4 mg/kg’.

- style doses (and concentrations) as mg/kg not mg kg⁻¹
- specify dose before drug. For example, ‘4 mg/kg ivermectin’, not ‘ivermectin 4 mg/kg’.

Drug manufacturers should be the manufacturer when work was done/paper written. They are specified following a trade name (see below).

Generic rINN (Recommended International Non-proprietary Names) should be used with the exceptions of adrenaline (not epinephrine) and noradrenaline (not norepinephrine). More information can be found at who.int/medicines/services/inn/en/

- under the rINN system, 'sulph' drugs are spelt 'sulf' (ie, sulfamethoxazole).
- some authors may refer to acetaminophen – this should be changed to paracetamol.

iv, im, po, sc – write out in full the first time they are used in the main text. The abbreviations can be used in tables but should be defined below the table.

q in a dosage should be written out as 'every'.

sid, bid, tid and qid – write out as 'once a day'/'once daily', 'twice a day'/'twice daily', 'three times a day' and 'four times a day'.

Trade names – if an author uses a trade name, put it in brackets after the rINN, and the manufacturer/marketing authorisation holder should be included. Use a semi-colon to punctuate. For example, 'meloxicam (Loxicom; Norbrook Laboratories)'.

Figures

Use an initial capital letter and the abbreviation 'Fig' when referring to a specific figure in the text.

Figure captions use the abbreviation Fig plus the appropriate number, followed by a colon (e.g., Fig 1:). They do not need a full stop at the end.

Figure captions should stand alone, with all abbreviations written out in full on first occurrence.

In general, captions do not start with an article ('A'/'The').

In captions for multipart figures, place the letter referring to a particular part of a figure before the section of the caption describing that part. For example, 'Fig 1: (a) Sagittal and (b) transverse sections through...'.

When redrawing or relabelling a figure, use Meta Pro Light.

Picture/photograph credits consist of just the name of the person or organisation supplying the image. In the print journals they are placed on one of the vertical sides of the image.

All photographs should be in CMYK mode and saved as eps files.

Headlines and titles

In general, headlines for articles and titles of research papers should not begin with a definite or indefinite article. For example, 'RCVS defends telemedicine debate' not 'The RCVS...' and 'Survey of' not 'A survey of'.

The titles of research papers should state the animal species.

Honorifics

Do not use honorifics such Mr, Mrs, Miss, Ms, Dr. Use the individual's first name and surname/family name the first time they are mentioned, then refer to them by surname/family name only. But bear in mind the author's voice and, for example, in the case of fictional client-based situations, the client would be referred to as 'Mr Smith', 'Ms Jones', etc.

Hyphens

See 'Punctuation'

Italic text

Genes are italicised, but not the proteins they code for.

Genus and species names are italicised, including for viruses. Kingdom, phylum, class, order, and family names are not italicised.

Latin terms such as *ad libitum*, *in vitro*, *in vivo* are not italicised.

Language

Appropriate language

Avoid language that could be perceived as discriminatory. Use gender-neutral terms whenever possible (e.g., chair not chairman, spokesperson not spokesman/spokeswoman, intermediary not middleman). Only use 'our' in editorials, otherwise edit to a suitably impersonal term.

Sex discrimination refers to discrimination based on the biological differences between male and female.

Gender discrimination refers to discrimination based on social behaviour, for example, not conforming to gender roles such as sexual orientation or identity.

Racially appropriate language – avoid using 'BAME' (black, Asian and minority ethnic) and BME (black and minority ethnic). Use 'ethnic minority' instead. Note that one definition of 'minority' is 'a group that is different racially, politically, etc, from a larger group of which it is a part'; therefore, 'group' is not needed after 'ethnic minority'. 'Black' is acceptable as long as it is used appropriately.

Author's voice

As a general rule, follow the style rules set out in this guide. However, there are sections of *Vet Record* and *In Practice* where it is important to respect the author's voice and follow the style that they use. For example, if a client has written something, and uses the term 'put to sleep', it would be inappropriate to change this to 'euthanased'. The sections likely to be affected include (but are not restricted to) Client View, My View and other opinion pieces, Careers, Balance, Letters (depending on author), Everyday Ethics, Practitioner Ponders.

Lists

Bullets – lists in the veterinary journals use bullets not numbers. Each bullet is followed by an en space but there is no indented alignment in subsequent lines.

Lists of short items (single or few words) should be introduced by a sentence or phrase that ends with an introductory colon. Also, there should be:

- no initial capitals
- no punctuation at the end of each bullet point BUT
- a full stop following the final entry.

Lists of longer phrases – where each item completes the introductory sentence or phrase, you should:

- end the introductory sentence with a colon;
- label each item with a bullet;
- start each item with a lowercase letter;
- end each item with a semicolon;
- close the list with a full stop.

Lists of complete sentences are preceded by a full sentence ending with a full stop.

- Each item is labelled with a bullet.
- Each item should start with a capital letter and end with a full stop.
- In lists of this format, it is acceptable for each bullet point to comprise more than one sentence.

Lists should be followed by a line space.

If writing a long form list (i.e., a series of sentences or paragraphs), use 'first', 'second', 'third' (not 'firstly', 'secondly', 'thirdly').

Miscellaneous

Annex 3 lists examples of common areas of confusion, how the veterinary journals use particular words and phrases and preferred spellings.

Numbers and units

Spell out numbers one to nine unless followed by a quantifying unit (weight, length, volume, per cent, etc). The veterinary journals do not count animals/objects/periods of time as quantifying units, so 'three dogs', 'nine cats', 'two books', 'three weeks', 'eight hours'. When referring to a specific day of a clinical trial, assessment period, section of a book (or similar) use a numeral. For example, 'tests were carried out on day 3 of the trial'; 'section 3 refers to'.

Spell out numbers at the beginning of sentences, hyphenating any compound numbers. For example, 'One hundred and forty-five . . .'

Use a comma in numbers upwards of 10,000.

Spell out 'million' and 'billion'. For example, '1 million sheep' not '1m sheep'.

Use SI units with a space between the number and the unit. For example, '4 mg/kg'. Use abbreviated forms of units unless being used as a noun within a sentence. For example, 'several litres of water', 'many metres of bandage'.

Dalton/kilodalton – Da/kDa, not D.

Decimal places – be consistent within an article/paper in the number of decimal places used.

Degrees – use a degree symbol only in association with temperatures and close it up to the number (15°C). When talking about degrees in association with angles, write it out. For example, 'at an angle of 15 degrees'.

Fractions – hyphenate fractions ('two-thirds'), and use 'one' rather than 'a'. For example, 'one-third' not 'a third'.

International units – lower case for the abbreviation iu.

Less than/more than should be written out in full in text in the main body of the journal unless within brackets. For example: 'The liver contained more than 12 mg/kg copper (reference range <5 mg/kg).' Remember that 'at least' is a shorter way of saying 'equal to or greater than'. In research papers it is acceptable to use <, ≤, > and ≥ without writing them out in full.

Negative numbers are indicated with an en dash (–5)

Ordinals – spell out ordinals up to ninth, then 10th. No superscript for 'th'.

Percentages – write out 'per cent' in text, but the % sign can be used in boxes and tables.

Punctuation

Apostrophes

- When used to indicate possession on words ending in 's', a second 's' is not required after the apostrophe. For example, RCVS', James'.
- No apostrophes are needed in 1970s, 1980s, CDs, PCs, etc.
- An apostrophe is needed in cases such as 'three months' treatment', 'six months' gestation' but not in cases such as 'three weeks old' or 'three months pregnant'. Basically, if you could replace the apostrophe with 'of' and the phrase still makes sense, then you need the apostrophe ('six months of gestation' but not 'three months of pregnant').

Brackets – order of bracket style is ([{ . Where text has been added in-house for clarity (eg, to a section of quoted text), the added text should be enclosed within square brackets.

Colons – do not use a capital letter on the word following a colon unless it is a proper noun.

Comma – do not use an Oxford/serial comma before 'and' unless it helps with clarity. For example, 'The horses were grey, brown and white and black' – in this case, an Oxford comma will help clarify if the horses were 'grey, brown and white, and black' or 'grey, brown, and white and black'.

Ellipsis (...) – use to indicate where sections of text have been omitted. No space on either side of the ellipsis. The Mac keyboard shortcut is alt;

En dashes – use a closed-up en dash to indicate a range (e.g., 25–30) and to indicate 'minus' (–5). Spaced en dashes can be used instead of brackets to separate off sections of sentences.

Exclamation marks – use sparingly.

Hyphens

- Avoid using hyphens in compound words, but hyphenate where there is a double letter combination or where it helps clarity. For example, 'anti-inflammatory', 'intra-abdominal',

'micro-organism', 'under-recognised', 're-examine', 're-treat' (as in 'treat again' rather than 'retreat' in the sense of 'back off'). Exceptions are coordinate, coordination, cooperate, cooperation, which are not hyphenated.

- Use hyphens in compound modifiers. For example, 'part-time working' (but note that it would be 'working part time'), 'long-term treatment', 'drug-related side effect'.
- Do not use hyphens in adverb-adjective modifiers where the adverb ends in 'ly'. For example, 'naturally occurring reaction', 'experimentally infected pig'.
- For the prefix 'anti', follow the style in Chambers dictionary; if the word is not listed, include a hyphen. For example, 'anti-government'.
- Hyphenate fractions. For example, 'one-third'.
- Do not hyphenate 'well xxx' unless used as an adjective. For example, 'It is a well-known problem but 'The problem is well known'.
- 'Non' words are hyphenated.
- 'Quality of life' is not hyphenated even when used as an adjective (e.g., quality of life tool).
- Use hyphens to join two names together (e.g., in names of stains or statistical tests) not en dashes (e.g., Kruskal-Wallis).

Quotation marks – single quotation marks are style. Use double quote marks if text is quoted within a quote. If a quote runs over more than one paragraph, an opening quote mark is placed at the start of second and any subsequent paragraphs to indicate that the quote is continuing. A closing quote mark is only required at the eventual end of the quoted text. Annex 2 gives examples of punctuating quoted text.

Qualifications

An individual's qualifications are only listed in obituaries.

Ranges

Use a closed up en dash to indicate a range when enclosed in brackets or in tables (e.g., 10–25).

In text, write out 'to' (e.g., 10 to 25).

When expressing a period of time such as a season, use / to indicate. For example, 'the winter of 2012/13'.

Rates

Incidence is the number of *new* or *newly diagnosed* cases of disease that occur within a period of time (e.g., per month, per year). It is best expressed as a fraction of the population at risk of developing the

disease (e.g., per 100 herds). For example: 'The incidence of bTB was 6.5 per 100 herds in 2010' means that 6.5 *new* cases of bTB were diagnosed per 100 herds in 2010.

Morbidity is the number of animals becoming ill.

Mortality is the number of animals dying.

Prevalence is the *actual number* of cases of disease in a population at or over a given time and indicates how widespread a disease is. For example, 'The prevalence of bTB was 40 per 100 herds in 2010' means that there were a total of 40 cases of bTB per 100 herds in 2010.

References

Vet Record, *Vet Record Open* and *Vet Record Case Reports* use a modified Vancouver style of referencing. *In Practice* uses Harvard referencing. Annex 1 gives details of style for both systems.

In text, use 'et al' when referring to a paper with multiple authors, but if referring to a group of researchers, use 'and colleagues'. For example, 'The paper by Phillips et al, summarised in this week's *Vet Record*, records...' but 'In their study, Phillips and colleagues investigated...'.

Spelling and style

We use '-is/ys' spellings rather than '-iz/yz', unless part of an organisation's name. For example, World Health Organization, Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations.

Unless otherwise stated, when two variant spellings are offered by a dictionary, select the first option. For example, 'adviser' not 'advisor' but note 'carcase' and not 'carcass'.

Annex 3 lists the preferred spelling and usage of various words.

If no detail can be found in this style guide, revert to *The Guardian's* style guide at www.theguardian.com/guardian-observer-style-guide-a

Tables

When referring to a specific table in the text, use an initial capital letter ('Table 1').

Begin each new entry in a column/row with an initial capital letter unless a symbol such as α or β is the first letter of an entry.

Abbreviations used in tables should be defined within the table or listed and defined under it in alphabetical order. Abbreviation definitions appear after any footnote explanations and can run on from each other.

Errors, deviations, intervals, and significance levels – the abbreviations SE (standard error), SD (standard deviation) and CI (confidence or credible interval) should be capitalised, as should the P in P values. These abbreviations are incorporated into headings following the form 'measurement (SE/SD) unit' or 'measurement unit (CI). For example, when referring to the 'mean (SD) cell size', the form would be 1727.6 (232.5) μm^2 . Or, when referring to a measurement with a confidence interval, the form would be '82% (95% CI=66.3–100)'.

Footnote symbols are superscript within the body of the table and in the explanation at the foot of the table. The order of footnote symbols is *, †, ‡, §, ¶, **, ††, ‡‡, §§, ¶¶, etc. Each footnote explanation starts on a new line.

Numbers in tables should be numerals and not written out, even if less than 10.

% symbols are used in tables, not 'per cent'.

Time

Use the 24-hour clock but bear in mind the context and author's voice. In some circumstances it may sound too 'military' to use the 24-hour clock.

A colon is used to make it clear that the figure is time (07:15, 17:30, 19:00).

Annex 1: References

Vet Record, Vet Record Open, Vet Record Case Reports

References should be given in the **Vancouver** format.

In the text references should be numbered as they appear. In the reference list they should be given in numerical order.

Papers

Punctuation of references must follow adapted Vancouver style:

Lastname AB, Lastname CD. Article title. *Journal title* Year;vol:start page–end page

Use one space only between words up to the year and then no spaces. The journal title should be in italics and abbreviated according to the style of Index Medicus. If the journal is not listed in Index Medicus then it should be written out in full. List the names and initials of all authors if there are 3 or

fewer; otherwise list the first 3 and add et al. The year of the document should be represented in four-digit format.

For example: You CH, Lee KY, Chey RY, et al. Electrogastrographic study of patients with unexplained nausea, bloating and vomiting. *Gastroenterology* 1980;79:311–14

Papers published ahead of print (that have not been allocated to an issue) should include the date published online, the doi number and the statement 'Epub ahead of print' in brackets.

For example: Vilalta C, Sanhueza JM, Murray D, Johnson L, Pieters M. Detection of *Mycoplasma hyopneumoniae* in piglet processing fluids. *Vet Rec* 2019; August 13, doi: 10.1136/vr.105475 (Epub ahead of print)

Books

Personal author(s):

Colson JH, Armour WJ. Sports Injuries and their Treatment. 2nd rev edn. London: St Paul, 1986

Editor(s), compiler as author:

Diener HC, Wilkinson M, eds. Drug-induced Headache. New York: Springer-Verlag, 1988

Organisation as author and publisher:

Virginia Law Foundation. The Medical and Legal Implications of AIDS. Charlottesville: The Foundation, 1987

Chapter in a book:

Weinstein L, Swartz MN. Pathologic properties of invading micro organisms. In: Sodeman WA Jr, Sodeman WA, eds. Pathologic Physiology Mechanisms of Disease. Philadelphia: Saunders, 1974: 457–72

Conference paper

Harley NH. Comparing radon daughter dosimetric and risk models. In: Gammage RB, Kaye SV, eds. Indoor air and human health. Proceedings of the Seventh Life Sciences Symposium; 29–31 October 1984, Knoxville (TN) Chelsea (MI): Lewis, 1985:69–78

Websites

Websites are referenced with their URL and access date. Access date is important, as websites can be updated and URLs change. The "data accessed" can be later than the acceptance date of the paper, and it can be given as the month the site was accessed.

Department of Health. Best practice guidelines for doctors and other health professionals on the provision of advice and treatment to young people under 16 on contraception, sexual and reproductive health. 2004. www.dh.gov.uk/ (accessed 3 March 2006)

In Practice

References are cited in chronological order in the text (with the oldest first) and alphabetically in the reference list. In the text references are cited within brackets using 'and others' for references with

more than two authors; if more than one cited reference was published in a particular year, then these should be cited alphabetically.

For example: 'Previous studies have found similar results (Smith and Jones 2010, Jones and Smith 2011, Jones and others 2012, Smith and others 2012).'

If the same set of authors published more than one reference in the same year, these should be designated 'a', 'b', etc, with the 'a' reference being the reference that appears first in the alphabetical reference list (NOT necessarily the reference that is cited first in the text).

If the same set of authors published multiple papers over several years, group them together.

For example: (Smith and others 1998, 2001a, 2015)

In the reference list, the following styles apply. If there are more than seven authors in total, use 'and others' after the seventh.

Papers

LASTNAME, A. B., LASTNAME, C. D., LASTNAME, E. F. & LASTNAME, G. H. (Year) Title of paper. *Journal name* **volume number**, page number-page number

For example: YANG, P. C., CHU, R. M., CHUNG, W. B. & SUNG, H. T. (1999) Epidemiological characteristics and financial costs of the 1997 foot-and-mouth disease epidemic in Taiwan. *Veterinary Record* **145**, 731-734

Books

Whole book

LASTNAME, A. B., LASTNAME, C. D., LASTNAME, E. F. & LASTNAME, G. H. (Year) Title of book.
Publisher

For example: RAMSEY, I. (2017) BSAVA Small Animal Formulary 9th edn, Part A: Canine and Feline. British Small Animal Veterinary Association

Chapter within a book

LASTNAME, A. B. (Year) Title of chapter. In: Title of book. Ed/Eds if appropriate. Publisher. page number-page number

For example: LEE, J. A. (2019) Decontamination and toxicological analyses of the poisoned patient. In: Textbook of Small Animal Emergency Medicine Volume 2. Eds K. J. Drobatz, K. Hopper, E. Rozanski, D. C. Silverstein. Wiley Blackwell. pp 821-830

Proceedings

LASTNAME, A. B., LASTNAME, C. D., LASTNAME, E. F. & LASTNAME, G. H. (Year) Title of paper given at the conference/meeting. Title of the proceedings. Eds (if appropriate), Town, Country, Month date a to b, Year. page number-page number (if appropriate)

For example: MILLER, W. (1976) A state-transition model of epidemic foot-and-mouth disease. Proceedings of an International Symposium: New Techniques in Veterinary Epidemiology and Economics. Reading, UK, July 12 to 15, 1976. p 56

Websites

LASTNAME, A. B., LASTNAME, C. D., LASTNAME, E. F. & LASTNAME, G. H. (Year) Title of page. Website address. Date accessed

For example: DEFRA (2019) Bringing your pet dog, cat or ferret to the UK. www.gov.uk/take-pet-abroad. Accessed August 19, 2019

Annex 2: Punctuation of quoted text

All the punctuation marks that logically belong with the quoted words are placed inside the quote marks, all the others are placed outside them.

- If you are quoting a full sentence, the full stop goes inside the quote marks.
 - The BVA said, 'There is an immediate need to return vets to the Shortage Occupation List.'
- If only parts of a sentence are being quoted, then any punctuation that doesn't belong to the quoted words goes outside the quote marks.
 - The BVA described returning vets to the Shortage Occupation List as 'an immediate need'.
- When following a quoted sentence with 'said xxx', a comma is needed inside the quote mark at the end of the quote.
 - 'There is an immediate need to return vets to the Shortage Occupation List,' said the BVA.
- If the quoted sentence ends with a question mark or an exclamation mark, you don't need to add the comma as well, just stick to the punctuation of the quoted phrase.
 - 'Is there a need to return vets to the Shortage Occupation List?' asked the BVA.
 - 'Vets should be returned to the Shortage Occupation List immediately!' exclaimed the BVA.
- If 'said xxx' appears in the middle of a quoted complete sentence, a comma is placed inside the quote marks at the end of the first part of the quote, and then a full stop inside the quote mark at the end of the quote.
 - 'There is,' said the BVA, 'an immediate need to return vets to the Shortage Occupation List.'
- If 'said xxx' is used after quoting only a few words from a sentence the comma goes outside the quote mark.

- There was 'an immediate need', said the BVA, to return vets to the Shortage Occupation List.

Annex 3: Areas of confusion, preferred word use and spelling

affect/effect – 'affect' (verb) means to 'act on' or 'influence', while 'effect' (noun) means 'something that is produced by a cause' or 'result' or the 'power or ability to influence something'.

aged/old – 'age(d)' and 'old' should not be used simultaneously when discussing how old something is. For example, 'The cats ranged in age from three to five years' or 'The cats were between three and five years old.'

among/amongst – do not use 'amongst'.

among/between – 'among' tends to be used when three or more things, or a composite group, are involved (eg, 'among the cats' would suggest that there are more than two cats involved). 'Between' tends to be used when there are two things involved (eg, 'between the cats' would suggest there are two cats). However, 'between' is sometimes used where more than two things are being considered, particularly if these things can be described precisely (eg, 'Discussions between the BVA, the RCVS and Defra are ongoing').

animals should (generally) be referred to as 'it', not 'he' or 'she'; however, bear in mind the author's voice/nature of the section. For example, in 'Client view' articles, it would be inappropriate to expect a pet owner to refer to their pet as 'it'.

antibody/antibodies – 'antibodies to' not 'antibodies against'.

antimicrobial/antibiotic – antimicrobials act against microbes: bacteria, virus, fungus; while antibiotics act against bacteria only. Antimicrobial is generally used as it is the broader term, but depends on the context of the piece.

castrated – use 'neutered' unless you are referring to the procedure for neutering a male animal (eg, 'open castration').

compared to/compared with – 'compared to' is used when looking at similarities between things, 'compared with' is used to point out differences.

comprise – means 'contain' or 'consist of' and does not need to be followed by 'of'. For example, 'The group comprised representatives of the profession.' Alternatively, use 'composed of' (meaning 'made up of'). For example, 'The group was composed of representatives of the profession.'

Day 1 competences – note that this style differs from the RCVS' style.

data – is the plural of 'datum', so 'the data are' not 'the data is'.

different from – not different to.

enquire/inquire – 'enquire' means 'to seek by questioning', 'inquire' means 'to make a search or investigation'.

et al should be used when referring to the authors of a paper but 'and colleagues' can be used if referring to a research group. For example 'The paper by Smith et al'. 'Smith and colleagues report'.

euthanased not euthanised or put down.

fetus/fetal not foetus/foetal.

gender – do not use when referring to animals, the correct word is 'sex'.

impact – can be both noun and verb.

infection/infestation – 'infection' is used when referring to endoparasites (worms, etc); 'infestation' is used when referring to ectoparasites (fleas, lice, mites, etc).

intact – do not use in the context of unneutered animals, use entire. For other uses (eg, to mean 'not broken'), intact is OK to use.

latter/last – 'latter' is the second of two, 'last' is the final one of many.

lead/led – 'lead' can be both noun (as in 'dog lead' or the metallic element) and verb (as in 'to lead the way'). 'Led' is the correct spelling of the past participle of 'to lead'. For example, 'He led the dog by its lead' or 'She had been asked to take the lead so she led the way into the lead mine with the dog on its lead.'

less/fewer – less means less in quantity, fewer means smaller in number. So, if you can count something, use 'fewer', if you can't count something, use 'less'. For example, 'less water' (because you can't count water), 'fewer cats' (because you can count cats).

licence/license – 'licence' is a noun and refers to a document that gives the holder permission to do something. 'License' is a verb and refers to the process of granting a licence. Note that American English uses 'license' as both noun and verb.

more than/over – 'over' can be used to mean 'more than'.

none – is singular and should be followed by 'was' not 'were'.

oestrous/oestrus – 'oestrous' is an adjective to describe the whole of the ovarian (oestrous) cycle; 'oestrus' is a noun to describe the state of sexual receptivity (ie, 'at oestrus').

past/last – 'past' is used for a period of time; for example, 'the past four months', 'past 10 years'. 'Last' refers to a specific time, for example, 'last week', 'last month'.

'penia' is correct, not 'paenia'. For example, leukopenia, cytopenia.

postmortem examination should be used rather than autopsy or necropsy. Remember that 'postmortem' means 'after death' so check whether a sentence makes sense with or without 'examination'. For example, 'The lamb was examined postmortem' (literally, 'The lamb was examined after death') makes sense, but 'The lamb was submitted for postmortem' ('The lamb was submitted for after death') does not, and 'examination' is therefore needed in this sentence.

practice/practise – 'practice' is a noun and refers to a usual or customary action, or to a veterinary premises or business. 'Practise' is a verb and refers to doing something. For example, 'Vets practise veterinary medicine in a veterinary practice.' 'It is common practice to practise veterinary medicine in a veterinary practice.' American English uses 'practice' as both noun and verb.

prior to/before – avoid using 'prior to' if possible, use 'before' instead (one word instead of two).

that/which – 'that' defines, 'which' informs. 'The cat that was injured was caught for treatment' defines exactly which cat was caught for treatment. 'The cat, which was injured, was caught for treatment' informs you why the cat was caught for treatment.

try to do something – not 'try and do something' (although in speech, people tend to say that they are going to 'try and', so if quoting someone, and they said 'try and', don't change it).

usage/use/utilise – all have slightly different meanings. 'Usage' is a noun and implies *how* something is used, or a custom or habit. 'Use' can be both noun and verb, but when used as a verb means 'to put into service or action'. 'Utilise' tends to imply a deliberate decision to use something for a particular purpose (but 'use' can often be used instead of 'utilise').

whether – does not need to be followed by 'or not'. 'Whether' itself implies that there is an alternative.

while/whilst – do not use 'whilst'.

x-ray (note lower case 'x') should be used only in the context of the radiation itself; otherwise refer to radiography/radiograph as appropriate.

Other preferred spellings/usage

acute phase no hyphen - so acute phase protein, acute phase response

adviser not advisor, but advisory

aetiology not etiology

air sac(s) two words

airsacculitis one word

amoxicillin not amoxycillin

and/or is acceptable

Angora goat has a capital letter

anti-rabbit, anti-dog etc

app can be used in short form, instead of application

artefact not artifact

axes x and y lower case

bar code two words

Battersea Dogs & Cats Home

B cell/lymphocyte no hyphen

blackfaced no hyphen

bluefaced no hyphen

bloodstream one word

body condition scores given in numbers either as whole number or half number, eg, 3.5.

bodyweight one word

Border disease (virus) capital 'B'

Borna disease (virus) capital 'B'

bottlenose dolphin

bovine viral diarrhoea virus not bovine virus diarrhoea virus

brainstem one word

British Veterinary LGBT+ group (can be shortened to BVLGBT+ from second use). The group represents lesbian, gay, bisexual and transgender members of the veterinary team, plus those with other sexual and gender identities.

buffaloes plural for buffalo

by-products with a hyphen

caeca is plural, the singular is caecum; 'caecae' is incorrect.

caesarean not caesarian and not with an initial capital. Should be followed by 'section'

carcase not carcass

chi-squared test no capital letters

chromosomes upper case XX, XY

coloration no 'u'

colorimetry no 'u'

journal title

concentrations should be in the format '10 mg/kg', not '10 mg kg⁻¹'. Particularly watch out for this in papers on anaesthesia as the anaesthesiologists tend to use the latter style.

cost-effective hyphenated

Covid-19 the disease caused by severe acute respiratory syndrome coronavirus 2 (SARS-CoV2). Refer to in full, not coronavirus 2

crossbreed/crossbred not hyphenated

cyathostomin is the new name for cyathostome

Dalmatian not 'Dalmation'

defecation not defaecation

Diff-Quik stain

discoloration no 'u'

diskospondylitis not discospondylitis

dobermann not dobermann pinscher, also lower case

downwind one word

dust-bath(ing) hyphenated

edge area (bovine TB). Lower case

end point two words

entire not 'intact' in the context of 'unneutered' only, eg, an entire male dog.

faeces, faecal and so on, but defecation

feather pecking no hyphen

feedingstuff one word

fetus, fetal and so on, not foetus. Plural is fetuses not feti

focus focused, focusing, focuses

follow up no hyphen when used as a verb (to follow up), but hyphenated when used as a noun, (eg, 'at long-term follow-up')

foodborne one word

footbath one word

footrot one word

foreleg/forelimb one word

formol solution not formal

free-living hyphenated when used as an adjective. Otherwise it is two words

free-range hyphenated when used as an adjective, for example, free-range eggs.

full-time hyphenated when used as an adjective. Otherwise it is two words

Fusobacter is the new name for *Fusobacterium*

gall bladder two words

gamebird one word

GenBank

gentamicin not gentamycin

German shepherd dog not German shepherd

gonadotrophin not gonadotropin

great dane both lower case

haem- not hem

headshaking one word

healthcare one word

herpesvirus one word. When the name is written out in full there is no hyphen, eg, equine herpesvirus type 1, but the abbreviation is hyphenated, EHV-1

herriot James Herriot

high-risk area (bovine TB) hyphenated and lower case. Not hyphenated if standalone, ie, high risk. Abbreviated to HRA.

hilum not hilus

hindleg/ hindlimb one word

Holstein-Friesian hyphenated

homeopathy not homoeopathy (NB: change to our previous style)

housefly one word

illthrift one word, not ill thrift or ill-thrift

inappetence/inappetent not inappetance/inappetant

inoculated on to not into (unless referring to liquid media, in which case 'into' is correct)

judgement not judgment

Harper and Keele vet school - do not use '&'

learned not learnt

leuko not leuco

life cycle two words

life span two words

liveweight one word

longhair one word

low-risk area (bovine TB) hyphenated and lower case. Not hyphenated if standalone, ie, low risk. Abbreviated to LRA.

meticillin not methicillin (rINN style)

miosis (constriction of the pupil) not myosis. Not to be confused with meiosis (cell division) or **myiasis** (fly infestation)

multicat one word

neuron not neurone

no-deal (when referring to Brexit) always hyphenate

oedema not edema

official veterinarian no capitals

on-farm should be hyphenated

orthopoxvirus one word

ostertagiosis

parapoxvirus one word

polydipsia

polar bear lower case 'p'

policymakers one word

preventive not preventative

program only use in connection with computer software, otherwise always use programme

protozoa this is the plural. The singular is 'protozoon' and the adjectives are 'protozoan' and 'protozoal'

pruritus not pruritis, but pruritic

psittacine should only be used as an adjective, the noun is psittaciform

raccoon not racoon

record-keeping with a hyphen

regimen not regime, for example, feeding regimen, treatment regimen, and so on. Regime is used only in a political context

rehome no hyphen

resistant to not against

restriction enzymes are written as, for example, EcoRI, BamHI

rose bengal lower case

roundtable one word when referring to a meeting or gathering, two words when referring to a table that is round

ruminal not rumenal

sandfly one word

sanguineous (note the 'e')

sarcoma plural is sarcomas

scour should be changed to diarrhoea (scour is not a scientific term) in scientific articles (but term is acceptable in surveillance reports from APHA and SRUC etc)

sea lion two words

sensitive to not against

self isolating no hyphen

sett badger sett

sex is the correct term and should be used in place of 'gender' in research papers

Shiga toxin

shorthair one word, eg, domestic shorthair

side effects no hyphen

skill set two words

south-east hyphenated when used as an adjective (eg, 'south-east England' but 'in the south east')

stillbirth/stillborn one word

Student's t test

syncytial two 'y's and one 'i'

Teflon do not use; use polytetrafluoroethylene (PTFE)

tendonitis not tendinitis

top-up hyphenated when as an adjective, eg, top-up fees

underrate not hyphenated

under-report hyphenated

up-to-date hyphenated when used as an adjective, eg, 'an up-to-date chapter' but not in 'the chapter is up to date'

vaccinate against not 'vaccinate for'. Also, prefer to state that vaccination is against a pathogen, not a disease

venepuncture not venipuncture

vectorborne one word

waterborne one word

wellbeing one word

worldwide one word

work-life balance

weight bearing two words unless used as an adjective

Wilcoxon rank-sum statistical test

yolk sac two words

youngstock one word

Ziehl-Neelsen stain

Annex 4: Useful abbreviations

Ab antibody (generally do not use as an abbreviation)

ABC avidin-biotin peroxidase complex

Ag antigen (generally do not use as an abbreviation)

AGIDT agar gel immunodiffusion test

ALP alkaline phosphatase

ALT alanine aminotransferase

AST aspartate aminotransferase

BAL bronchoalveolar lavage

BCVA British Cattle Veterinary Association

BEVA British Equine Veterinary Association

BSAVA British Small Animal Veterinary Association

BTSCC bulk tank somatic cell count

BHB beta-hydroxybutyrate

BRSV Bovine respiratory syncytial virus

CFT complement fixation test

cfu colony-forming units (NB lower case)
CK creatine kinase
CLA caseous lymphadenitis
CCN cerebrocortical necrosis
COSHH Control of Substances Hazardous to Health regulations
cpe cytopathic effect (NB lower case)
CVMP Committee for Veterinary Medicinal Products

DAT direct agglutination test
DMEM Dulbecco's minimum essential medium
DPBS Dulbecco's phosphate-buffered saline
dpi days postinfection (NB lower case)
DVM divisional veterinary manager

EAE enzootic abortion of ewes
EBL enzootic bovine leukosis
EfraCom Environment, Food and Rural Affairs Committee
EFSA European Food Safety Authority
EHEC enterohaemorrhagic *Escherichia coli*
EM electron microscopy
EMA European Agency for the Evaluation of Medicinal Products
EMS extramural studies
ETEC enterotoxigenic *Escherichia coli*
EEC European Economic Community (now the EU, but 'EEC' appears sometimes in the context of older European directives)

FAO Food and Agriculture Organization (note the 'z')
FAT fluorescent antibody test
FAVN fluorescent antibody virus neutralisation
FAWC Farm Animal Welfare Committee
FDA Food and Drug Administration
FMD foot-and-mouth disease
FSA Food Standards Agency
FVE Federation of Veterinarians of Europe

GGT γ -glutamyltransferase
GLDH glutamate dehydrogenase
GnRH gonadotrophin-releasing hormone
GSHPx glutathione peroxidase

HA haemagglutination
HACCP hazard analysis and critical control point
HAI haemagglutination inhibition test
Hb haemoglobin (generally do not use as an abbreviation)

HI haemagglutination inhibition
HSC Health and Safety Commission
HSE Health and Safety Executive

IFAT indirect fluorescent antibody test
IFN interferon (eg, IFN- γ)
IHC immunohistochemistry
IL interleukin (eg, IL-2)
IPMA immunoperoxidase monolayer assay
IPVS International Pig Veterinary Society
IPX immunoperoxidase assay

LAT latex agglutination test
LDH lactate dehydrogenase
LVI local veterinary inspector

mAb monoclonal antibody
MAT microagglutination test
MBM meat and bone meal
MEL maximum exposure limit
MEM minimum essential medium
MHS Meat Hygiene Service
MIC minimum inhibitory concentration
MRL maximum residue limit
MRSA meticillin-resistant *Staphylococcus aureus* (note rINN spelling 'meticillin')
MRSP meticillin-resistant *Staphylococcus pseudintermedius* (note rINN spelling 'meticillin')
MZN modified Ziehl-Neelsen

NADIS National Animal Disease Information Service
NEFA non-esterified fatty acid
NOAH National Office of Animal Health

OIE World Organisation for Animal Health (OIE)
OTMS over-30-months scheme
OV official veterinarian

PCV-2 porcine circovirus type 2
PDNS porcine dermatitis and nephropathy syndrome
PEDV porcine epidemic diarrhoea virus
PETS Pet Travel Scheme
PFGE pulsed-field gel electrophoresis
PGE parasitic gastroenteritis
PI3 parainfluenza virus type 3
PI Committee Preliminary Investigation Committee

PML pharmacy merchants list
PMWS postweaning multisystemic wasting syndrome
POM prescription-only medicine
PPH pruritus-pyrexia-haemorrhage (syndrome)
ppm parts per million (NB lower case)
PPV porcine parvovirus
PRRS(V) porcine reproductive and respiratory syndrome (virus)
PUPD polyuria/polydipsia

RBC red blood cell
RBT rose bengal test
RSV respiratory syncytial virus
RVC Royal Veterinary College
RT-PCR reverse transcriptase-PCR
RUMA Responsible Use of Medicines in Agriculture

SARSS Suspected Adverse Reaction Surveillance Scheme
SAT serum agglutination test
SCOPS Sustainable Control of Parasites in Sheep initiative
SEAC Spongiform Encephalopathy Advisory Committee
SEERAD Scottish Executive Environment and Rural Affairs Department
SNT serum neutralisation test
SPF specific pathogen-free
SOPs standard operating procedures
SPVS Society of Practising Veterinary Surgeons
SRM specified risk material

T₃ thyroid-stimulating hormone (note use of subscript)
T₄ thyroxine (note use of subscript)
TGEV transmissible gastroenteritis virus
TNF tumour necrosis factor
TRT turkey rhinotracheitis (virus)
TVI temporary veterinary inspector

VI virus isolation
VIC Veterinary Investigation Centre (note capitals)
VIDA Veterinary Investigation Diagnosis Analysis (the VLA's database)
VIO veterinary investigation officer
VMAT vaginal mucus agglutination test
VMD Veterinary Medicines Directorate
VN virus neutralisation
VPC Veterinary Products Committee
VPIS Veterinary Poisons Information Service
VRC Veterinary Residues Committee

VTEC verocytotoxin-producing *Escherichia coli*

WBC white blood cell

WHO World Health Organization (note the 'z')

ZN Ziehl-Neelsen

ZST zinc sulphate turbidity test